

The Wetlands



NORTH AMERICA'S RIVERS, lakes, marshes, and swamps, or the wetlands as they are known, are a rich environment for birds because of the variety of food and nesting places they provide. Many marshes, which were once protected so people could hunt the ducks and geese, are now nature reserves. In the southeast are swamps dominated by bald cypress trees draped with vines, Spanish moss, and orchids. These include the Florida Everglades and the bayous of the Mississippi delta. There is an amazing number of ponds and lakes in North America. Some formed where ice sheets dug hollows in the land. Others formed as a result of movements of the Earth's crust. Many rivers, lakes, and swamps are threatened by the pollution caused by farms and factories.



Belted kingfisher
(*Megasceryle alcyon*)
Length: 1 ft 1 in (33 cm)

The female has a chestnut color on her chest and flanks.

Stout, sharp bill for spearing fish

Belted kingfisher

This kingfisher usually hovers over the water, then plunges in to grab a fish in its strong beak. It also swoops close to the water's surface and dips down to catch a meal. It has a loud, rattling call, often made as it flies. The female lays her eggs at the end of a long tunnel in a steep bank near the water.

Head and neck are stretched out in flight.

Whooping crane

The whooping crane is one of the world's most endangered species. It almost died out in the 1940s, but its numbers are now increasing thanks to conservation. The whooping crane nests in northwestern Canada but migrates south to the warmer weather of Texas in winter. Its name comes from its loud, trumpeting call.

Whooping crane
(*Grus americana*)
Length: 5 ft 2 in (1 m 60 cm)

Common loon

The common loon, or great northern diver, as it is sometimes known, can plunge up to 266 ft (81 m) below the waters of lakes and rivers. Its feet are set well back on its body to push it through the water when it dives, but the bird finds it hard to walk on dry land. It sometimes produces a mournful, yodeling call or wails and laughs wildly.

In winter, the loon's plumage is much paler and duller than it is in summer.

Common loon
(*Gavia immer*)
Length: 3 ft (91 cm)

Winter

Summer



Lakes surrounded by coniferous forest, like this one on the northwest coast of Canada, are home to birds such as loons and cranes.

The Everglades (see map on facing page).